# Which Marketing Channels Are Wasting Spend?

Oct 24, 2026 · @B

## Business Question

Which marketing channels get more budget than the results they deliver? A marketing director has one budget to split across six platforms (Google Search, Meta, LinkedIn, TikTok, Snapchat, Google Display) and six campaign objectives (Sales, Leads, Traffic, Engagement, Video Views, Reach), and needs to know where money is being wasted.

The data has no profit margin, so a true break even return can't be known. I defined waste as spend that costs far more than its peers for the same job, judged against each campaign's own objective: ROAS for Sales and Leads, cost per click for Traffic and Engagement, cost per view for Video Views, and cost per thousand people reached for Reach.

I did not rank everything by ROAS. Four objectives (Reach, Traffic, Engagement, Video Views) have no revenue by design, and together they hold 70.19% of total spend, so a single ROAS ranking would judge most of the budget with a yardstick it can't pass.

## Data and Method

I compared each platform's share of spend with its share of results, one objective at a time, using SQL in PostgreSQL and a Power BI view for the final read.

**Data.** The MENA Digital Marketing Performance Dataset on Kaggle (by alinaboulsi, CC BY-SA 4.0): 30,000 daily ad level rows from January 2023 to December 2025, across six platforms. It is synthetic and benchmark based, so it shows the method and the pattern, not real account performance.

**Checks before analysis.**

- Four impossible value checks (negative values, clicks above impressions, conversions above clicks, zero spend rows) all returned 0.
- Dates arrived as DD/MM/YYYY text and were converted with TO_DATE.
- Conversions are heavily skewed (average 10.8, median 1), so I used totals and ratios of totals, not averages.

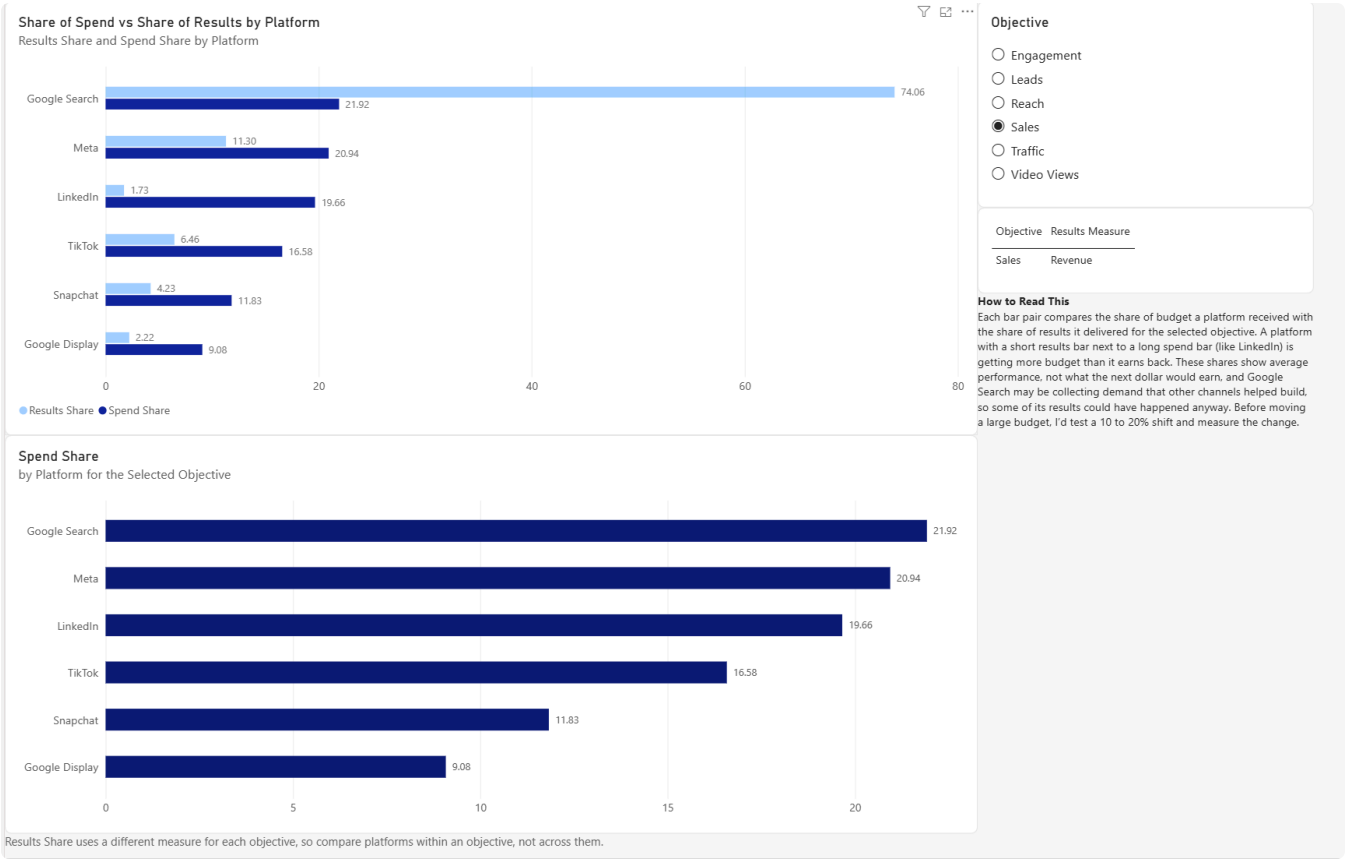
**Rules I held to.**

- Never average ratios. Sum the numerator and the denominator separately, then divide.
- Never blend objectives. Every query filters or groups by objective, because a blended number describes none of them.
- Compare shares only within one objective, using a window function: spend share is each platform's spend divided by SUM(SUM(spend)) OVER (PARTITION BY objective).

**What counts as a result** depends on the objective:

| Objective | Result Measure |
|---|---|
| Sales | Revenue |
| Leads | Conversions |
| Traffic | Clicks |
| Engagement | Clicks (the data has no likes, comments or shares) |
| Video Views | Video views |
| Reach | Reach, summed across campaigns (approximate) |

**Dashboard.** The main chart puts spend share next to result share for each platform, with a single select objective slicer so the shares never add up across objectives. A sorted bar chart shows spend share, a small table names the result measure for the selected objective, and a short note explains how to read the page.




# Findings

LinkedIn takes about 20% of spend on every objective and returns between 1.73% and 6.11% of the results, the biggest gap of any platform in all six objectives.

| Objective | LinkedIn Spend Share | LinkedIn Result Share | Gap (Points) |
|---|---|---|---|
| Leads | 21.05% | 2.45% | -18.60 |
| Sales | 19.66% | 1.73% | -17.93 |
| Traffic | 20.67% | 2.75% | -17.92 |
| Engagement | 19.18% | 2.49% | -16.69 |
| Reach | 20.70% | 6.11% | -14.59 |
| Video Views | 19.81% | 5.78% | -14.03 |

**The cause is mostly price, not audience behavior.**

- LinkedIn charges about $25 per thousand impressions (CPM), against $4 to $14 on the other platforms, so the same spend buys far fewer impressions.
- In Traffic its cost per click is $3.45, about 5.8x the next platform. In Engagement it is $3.52, about 5.5x Google Display.
- In Engagement its click through rate (0.71%) matches Google Display (0.70%), so the whole gap against Google Display is price per impression.
- In Video Views, view rates are close on every platform (18.55% to 21.08%), so cost per view follows price: $0.13 on LinkedIn against $0.02 on Snapchat.

**Sales return confirms it.** LinkedIn's Sales ROAS is 0.44, the only platform below 1.0. Its conversions are the most valuable (about $188.56 each), but each click costs about $3.08 and earns about $1.35. No country (ROAS 0.39 to 0.52) or theme reached 1.0, so there is no pocket worth rescuing.

**Google Search and Meta.** In Sales, Google Search took 21.92% of spend and produced 74.06% of revenue (ROAS 16.78), and Meta returned a more modest ROAS of 2.68. Google Search's results come from people who already searched for something, so its average return is not a promise about the next dollar.

## Recommendation

Cut LinkedIn's budget on Reach, Traffic, Engagement and Video Views by roughly half, move that money to cheaper platforms, and keep a capped LinkedIn test running. The half is a judgment call, not a number from the data, and this is a hypothesis to test, not a conclusion.

1. **What to do.** Move the freed budget to Meta and TikTok for clicks and conversions, and to Snapchat if cheap awareness is truly needed (Snapchat is the cheapest or close to it on Reach, Traffic, Engagement and Video Views).
2. **Hypothesis and test.** LinkedIn's gap is mostly price per impression, not campaign setup. Run a capped LinkedIn test with tighter targeting and fresh creative, judged on cost per click. From the Sales findings, break even needs CPC to fall from about $3.08 to under about $1.50. If it gets there, the problem was fixable. If CPC stays near $3 or higher, it was the platform's price.
3. **Tradeoff.** The plan gives up LinkedIn's professional audience, its high value Sales conversions, and any brand or pipeline effect this data can't measure. Meta and TikTok are real but modest on Sales (ROAS 2.68 and 1.93, against 16.78 for Google Search), and cheaper platforms get more expensive as spend grows.

4. **Risk if wrong.** If LinkedIn would have improved, the capped test limits the loss. If Meta and TikTok don't scale, shift budget in steps of 10 to 20% and check cost per click and ROAS after each step.
5. **Google Search is not a simple destination.** Its return is an average on current spend and comes from search intent, so the next dollar will likely earn less, and some of its revenue may have happened without the ad. Test a small shift before trusting the average.

## Limitations

The findings show a method and a pattern, and should not drive a real budget decision, because of these limits:

- The dataset is synthetic and benchmark based, and its own README says not to use it for real budget decisions.
- There is no profit margin, so ROAS can't be turned into profit.
- Leads revenue is a modeled proxy value, not money from a real sale.
- Clicks and views measure interest in an ad, not the quality of the visit. Clicks are the only engagement signal, since there are no likes, comments or shares.
- Summed reach double counts people, so Reach shares are approximate. The data also doesn't define what counts as a view on each platform.
- The 1.5x flag and the 100 click minimum used in the Traffic checks are placeholders chosen by judgment.
- There is no audience, ad copy, landing page, bidding or targeting data, so optimization problems can't be ruled in or out. I would request that data before any real decision.
- Shares show average performance. They can't say what an extra dollar on any platform would earn, which is why the recommendation is a staged test.